

DANIEL

Introduction

The statesman Daniel found himself in a unique position to write concerning God's sovereignty because he has seen his hometown, Jerusalem, controlled by the major powers Assyria, Egypt, Babylon, and Persia. Seen as a wise man rather than a prophet, the Jews classified this book with the Writings instead of the Prophets.

Author

Daniel's given name means "God is Judge." Deported to Babylon in 605 BC as a royal hostage, Daniel was probably a descendant of the royal family or at least a member of the upper class. He functioned much more as a statesman than as a prophet of God.

Date of Writing

Daniel was taken as a royal hostage in the first Babylonian deportation from Jerusalem in 605 BC (1:1). Almost three years later he had risen to substantial power and influence (2:1). Daniel's last dated prophecy (10:1) corresponds to 536 BC. Thus this book covers events within a seventy-year span (605-536 BC).

A number of liberal scholars vehemently object to such dating. They have presented numerous reasons which conservative scholarship has satisfactorily answered. The root issue seems to be the notion of a God who is sovereign and can determine future history.

Historical Setting

Daniel was taken captive as a royal hostage in 605 BC. Thus, as a youth, he experienced subjection to three different world powers: Assyria (until 609 BC), Egypt (609-605 BC), and Babylon (605 BC onward). Near the end of his life he was also subject to the Persian Empire. It appears he was always intensely interested in Judean events as evidenced by his well-known custom of praying toward Jerusalem three times daily (6:10). In this light the historical setting of this composition covers the events from approximately 610-530 BC in both the Levant and Mesopotamia.

The life and death struggle between Assyria and Babylon should have taken place at Carchemish in 609 BC. This ancient city, located about 60 miles north of Aleppo, controlled the primary ford of the Euphrates River. With Assyria on the defensive and in decline, Egypt under the direction of Pharaoh Necho II moved north along the International Coastal Highway. She planned to assist Assyria in her future conflict with Babylon. Egypt met with resistance in the Philistia Plain at both Migdol and Gaza. These cities attempted to delay the Egyptian forces so they could not assist Assyria in her desperate struggle against Babylon. Josiah also tried to block and stall Egypt at Megiddo. King Josiah became unsuccessful and lost his life in the process. Egypt arrived at Carchemish in time to participate in the bloody fray. Yet the conflict again ended without resolution. It did result in the collapse of the Assyrian Empire, but only staggered both Egypt and Babylon. However, by default, Egypt controlled the Levant in 609 BC.

Egyptian mastery of the Levant became evident to Judah as Pharaoh Necho returned to his homeland. Although Jehoahaz met Necho at Riblah, the Pharaoh still deposed him and replaced him with Eliakim whom he renamed Jehoiakim. Jehoahaz ruled for three months, but

maintained a pro-Babylon policy. Thus Necho replaced him and also place an onerous tribute on Israel.

The spiritually decadent Jehoiakim reigned 609-597 BC. He used forced, unpaid labor in order to build himself a luxurious palace. He also instituted exorbitant taxes. In 605 BC, Egypt confronted Babylon again at Carchemish. Babylon obtained a definite decision in her favor. An ensuing battle at Haran placed the last nail into the Egyptian coffin. About this time Nebuchadnezzar also obtained the Babylonian throne. He appeared outside of Jerusalem in 605 BC to make the Babylonian presence known. Although Jehoiakim retained the throne, Babylon took a number of royal hostages from the upper class. These initial exiles included Daniel and his three famous friends.

In 605 BC Nebuchadnezzar captured Ashkelon and deported her citizens. He continued his trek

Argument

I. GOD'S SOVEREIGNTY OVER INDIVIDUALS (1:1-21)

The first and smallest of the three major divisions of this composition addressed God's sovereignty over individuals. Thus "sovereignty" becomes the subject of the entire argument of this book.

A. Judah Humbled by God (1:1-2)

Daniel set the scene at the time when God humbled Judah. In 605 BC, Jehovah used His servant Nebuchadnezzar to humble Judah by military conquest. He breached the walls of Jerusalem and took some of the temple utensils back with him to Babylon.

B. Youth Deported (1:3-7)

He also deported numerous youth. These young men received the best education Babylon offered.

C. Four Trust God (1:8-16)

Of these royal hostages, four trusted God (1:8-16). Daniel, the principal personality of the four, resolved to remain undefiled in Babylon, much unlike most of the exiles (1:8). Daniel requested (1:9-14) kosher food. A ten-day test for the four resulted. The four passed the test with outstanding success (1:15-16). Thus they continued to receive kosher food regularly.

D. Four Exalted by God (1:17-21)

As a second consequence of their faith, God exalted the four (1:17-21). He rewarded them with incredible learning and understanding. Thus they entered the king's service with high ranking and prominence.

II. GOD'S SOVEREIGNTY OVER NATIONS (2:1-7:28)

A. THE FIRST DREAM OF NEBUCHADNEZZAR (2:1-49)

The second of the three major divisions of this work demonstrated God's sovereignty over the nations. The first of six incidents focused on the initial dream of Nebuchadnezzar. This incident provided the outline of Gentile domination.

1. The Dream Test (2:1-16)
 - a. The Test (2:1-3)

In 602 BC, almost three years after the fall of Jerusalem, Nebuchadnezzar presented to his wise men the dream test (2:1-16). The test itself (2:1-3) focused on one dream the king dreamt a number of times. These reoccurring dreams troubled him to the extent that he summoned his wise men. This test resulted in their failure (2:4-11). Suspecting that they could not objectively interpret the dream, the king asked the men to tell him first the dream and then interpret it. Threatened with dastardly consequences, the wise men could only unsuccessfully request that the king tell them the dream. In this manner they failed the test.

A furious king presented the punishment (2:12-13).

Outline

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